

The Operator's *Playbook*

The written manual for running a company with a crew of AI agents. From the desk that runs Modern Mustard Seed.

CHAPTER 8

Guardrails

Block what is never right

Ask about what cannot be undone

Allow everything else

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Fourteen chapters and a *checklist*.

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START

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The director's *job*

This is the manual for running a company with a crew of AI agents. It is written from the desk that runs Modern Mustard Seed: one person, a crew of Claude agents, and a studio that ships websites, voice agents, software and products for other businesses.

Nothing in here is theory. Every rule, every habit and every warning exists because the plain version of it went wrong at least once, usually in front of a customer. Where a rule cost us something, the cost is named, with the details stripped so it fits your business instead of ours.

The idea underneath the whole book is simple. The work left for a person, when a crew does the doing, is deciding what should exist and saying yes. You become the director of ideas. The crew writes, builds, checks, sends, reports and remembers. You choose, approve, and set the standard.

That sounds like less work. It is different work, and it has its own skills: writing a brief an agent can build from, writing rules an agent cannot misread, knowing which actions an agent may take alone and which must stop and ask, and reading fifteen minutes of briefing a day well enough to run the whole business from it.

Read it once front to back. Then keep it open during your first thirty days, and use the checklist at the end.

HOW TO READ THE BOXES

A **Law** box is a rule we never break. A **Paid for by** box is the incident that wrote it. A **Do this** box is a step to take today.

The shape of a *one-person company*

A one-person company is not a person doing everything. It is a person deciding everything, with a crew doing the rest.

What the crew does

Agents are good at work that has a clear input, a clear standard and a clear output: drafting the proposal from the call notes, checking the website every week, answering the missed call and booking the appointment, writing the monthly report, building the page from the brief, running the checks before a change goes live, and remembering everything anyone ever explained.

They are fast, tireless and consistent, provided the input, the standard and the output are written down. Most disappointment with agents is a missing brief, a missing rule or a missing check, not a missing capability.

What you do

- **Decide what should exist.** Which product, which offer, which customer, which job gets an agent next.
- **Set the standard.** The rules file, the skills and the guards are where your standard lives. You write them once and the crew applies them every time.
- **Say yes.** Anything that reaches a customer, moves money or changes production waits for you. Your approval is the last check, so it has to be a real one.
- **Read the briefing.** Fifteen minutes a day: what ran, what broke, what shipped, what waits on you.

The three layers

Every company run this way has the same three layers, and the rest of this book is about building each one.

1. **Knowledge.** The rules file, memory and skills. What the crew knows about your business and how you want things done.
2. **The crew.** Agents with one job each, a written charter, and a schedule for the work that repeats.
3. **Guardrails.** Hooks that make the dangerous things impossible, and a habit of checking that work is real before anyone calls it done.

Build them in that order. A crew without knowledge guesses. A crew without guardrails guesses with your money.

DO THIS

List every job you did last week, one per line. Mark each one: **decide** (only you), **approve** (the crew drafts, you say yes), or **crew** (the crew does it and reports). Most owners find more than half the list is crew work.

Directing *ideas*

Agents build what you said, not what you meant. Directing is the craft of closing that gap before anything is built.

The one-page brief

Every piece of work starts with a brief, and every brief has the same seven parts:

1. Who it is for, specifically enough to picture one person.
2. The problem, in that person's words.
3. What they do with it on the first day.
4. What it must never do.
5. The three things that would make it excellent.
6. What is out of scope.
7. How you will know it worked.

You do not have to write the brief yourself. Tell the agent the idea in one sentence and ask it to interview you, one question at a time, until it could explain the idea to a stranger. Then it writes the brief, and you approve or correct it. Ten minutes of interview saves a day of rebuilding.

The acceptance test

Right after the brief, ask for the acceptance test: a numbered list of things you can check yourself that prove the work is done. Every line must be something you can see, click, read or count. "Works correctly" is not a line. "Submitting the form with no email shows the sentence 'We need an email to send your quote'" is.

The acceptance test becomes the definition of done for every agent that touches the work. When an agent reports, it reports against the test, with evidence for each line.

The order of work

Anything bigger than one sitting gets broken into the smallest steps that each produce something you can look at. Two rules order the steps: the riskiest unknown is answered first, and every step leaves the project working. A bad day then costs one step, not the project.

The cut

Feature lists grow. The first version ships when someone removes things from it. Ask the agent to cut the list to the version a customer would pay for on day one, with one line for every cut item on why it can wait. If the kept list does not fit in a week of building, cut again.

LAW

Nothing is built before the brief and the acceptance test are approved.

PAID FOR BY

A page built from a one-line request that was beautiful, complete, and for the wrong customer. It was rebuilt from scratch the next day, from a brief.

The *rules file*

The rules file is the first thing every agent reads in every session. It is the closest thing your company has to a constitution.

What goes in it

- **Who you are.** The owner, the business, the customer, and the one idea everything you do carries.
- **What you sell.** Every package, its set price, what it includes. Agents quote only from this list.
- **The deliverable standard.** Finished work only. No drafts handed over as if they were done.
- **How you write.** Lead with the answer, no hedging, specific over general, the words you never use.
- **Pricing language.** How prices are stated and how they are never stated.
- **The tools.** Where things live and how they are reached.
- **The laws.** Short, absolute rules, each one paid for.

Writing a law

A law is one sentence, stated as a rule rather than a preference, with the incident that wrote it underneath. "Customer email apologizes once at most, never in the subject line" is a law. "Try to keep apologies brief" is a wish, and agents treat wishes as optional.

Before a new law goes in, it passes three questions:

1. If it is broken, does a customer, a lead or a search engine see the result?
2. Could an agent work it out from the files in front of it?
3. Has it already been broken once, or are you stating it as a firm rule?

All three must pass. Everything else is a memory note. The test keeps the file short, and a short file gets read. We hold ours at twenty laws.

Laws that belong in most rules files

The Studio Kit carries all twenty of ours, generalized. These six fit nearly every small business:

- Never tell anyone their business lacks something unless a tool read the live page today and did not find it.
- A lead is marked "contacted" only by a person.
- Everything we ship speaks as the business: we, us, our.
- Customer email apologizes once at most and never explains our internal mistakes.
- Adjustments to what we built are included and never get a price.
- Production ships one way, and nobody deploys from a laptop.

PAID FOR BY

An email that told a business owner their website had no phone number. It was in the footer. That one sentence ended a conversation that had been going well, and it is why the first law on the list exists.

Memory

The test of a crew is whether you ever have to explain the same thing twice.

One fact per note

Memory is a folder of short notes the crew reads when a subject comes up. Each note holds one fact: who a customer is and what they bought, where a file lives, why a decision was made, a trap that cost an afternoon. Each has a name, a one-line description that helps a future session decide whether it matters, a date, and two lines underneath: why it matters, and how to apply it.

The moment you explain something for the second time, ask the agent to save it. Before saving, it checks for a note that already covers the subject and updates that one instead of making a second.

An index that fits on a screen

The notes are listed in one index file, one line per note, loaded at the start of every session. When the index gets long, group the lines by subject. The index is what lets a session know a note exists without reading all of them.

Corrections replace, they do not stack

A wrong memory is worse than none, because the crew acts on it with confidence. When a fact changes, the old version is removed everywhere it appears: the note, any skill that repeats it, any line in the rules file. Leaving the old version with a correction underneath guarantees that some session reads the top half and stops.

What does not go in memory

- Anything the files already say. The code, the price list and the project history are the source; memory points at them.
- Anything that only matters to today's conversation.

- Passwords and keys, ever.

The handoff note

When a session ends with work unfinished, it writes a handoff note: what was finished and checked, what was finished and not checked, what was not started, the exact files and branch, any decision waiting on you, and the first command the next session should run. The next session starts where this one stopped instead of an hour earlier.

DO THIS

Write the five notes you would hand a new employee on day one: your best customer, your most common job, the tool that confuses everyone, the mistake you never want repeated, and where the important files live.

Skills

A skill is a playbook an agent follows the same way every time. It is how your standard survives a busy week.

When to write one

Write a skill the third time a job comes up. The first time, you learn what the job is. The second time, you notice what went wrong the first time. The third time, you write down how it is done, including what went wrong, so it never goes wrong that way again.

The anatomy

A skill is a folder with one file, `SKILL.md`. At the top, a name and a description. The description matters more than anything below it: it is what the crew reads to decide whether this skill applies, so it names the job and the exact phrases you use when you ask for it. Below that, the playbook:

1. What the job is for, in two sentences.
2. What to read before starting.
3. The steps, in order, each one checkable.
4. What it must never do.
5. What done looks like, and how it is reported.

Keep it under two pages. A skill nobody finishes reading is a skill nobody follows.

Ten skills to start

Most small businesses repeat the same ten jobs. The Studio Kit ships twelve, and these ten are where to begin: the quality bar, the shipping checks, your brand voice, the design loop, proposals, one-to-one outreach, onboarding, the monthly review, the morning briefing, and the workspace doctor that keeps the rest healthy.

Skills point; they do not copy

A skill that needs your prices points at the price list. It never types them in. When a price changes, it changes in one place and every skill is right the same minute.

PAID FOR BY

Three skills that each held their own copy of a package price. One was updated. The other two quoted the old price to a customer for a week.

The crew

One job each, a written charter, and work that is checked before it is called done.

The charter

An agent with a vague job does a bit of everything, badly. An agent with one job and written limits is predictable. Every agent on the crew has a charter of under one page:

- Its name and its one job, in one sentence.
- The phrases that should send work to it.
- What it reads first.
- What it produces, and where it saves it.
- What it must never do.
- When it must stop and ask you.
- How it reports.

The first crew

Start with two agents, the ones every attendee builds on Day 3:

- **The presence agent.** Every week it reads your website, your business profile and your reviews, scores your presence out of 100, and files the fixes in the order that recovers the most points for the least effort.
- **The front desk.** It answers the missed call, the form or the message within minutes, asks the three qualifying questions, books the appointment from your real calendar, and hands you a clean summary.

Add the third agent only when the first two have run clean for two weeks. Good next hires: a proposal writer, a monthly reporter, a follow-up writer, and an idea engine.

Crews by trade

TRADE	FIRST AGENTS AFTER THE TWO
Builders and remodelers	Plan-request follow-up, site walk booking, change-of-scope notes for the job file, weekly client update
Clinics	After-hours intake, cancellation list filler, review replies, recall reminders
Home services	Missed-call dispatcher, standard job quotes from a set list, arrival-window texts, seasonal reminder campaign
Agencies	Monthly client audit, report drafter, proposal writer, new-lead researcher

Delegating and checking

When a task has parts that do not depend on each other, send each part to its own agent with a complete brief and run them at the same time. Then check each result against its brief before anything is reported to you. Passing an agent's report straight upward is how unchecked work gets called done.

LAW

The director checks the work. An agent's report is a claim until someone has looked.

Schedules and *heartbeats*

The work that repeats should run without you asking, and should tell you when it did not.

Putting a job on a schedule

Any job that happens on a rhythm (the weekly presence check, the morning briefing, the follow-up sweep, the monthly reports) runs on a schedule. Before choosing a time, list every scheduled job that already exists.

LAW

No two scheduled jobs start on the same minute.

PAID FOR BY

Two jobs that both started at the top of the hour. They reached for the same records at the same moment. One finished; the other silently lost its write, and nobody noticed for a week. Odd minutes (7, 23, 38, 51) are the ones nobody else picks.

Heartbeats

A job that fails loudly is an annoyance. A job that stops quietly is a disaster that has not been noticed yet. Every scheduled job writes a heartbeat when it starts and when it finishes. The morning briefing reads the heartbeats and treats a job that did not report as a failure until proven otherwise.

Failing well

When a job fails, it leaves a note in plain words: what failed, what it was doing, and what it needs. "Error 500" is not a note. "The calendar connection expired; the front desk could not book three leads since 2 AM; reconnect the calendar in settings" is.

Switches

Anything that sends to customers on a schedule has an off switch you can reach from your phone, and it starts in the off position. You switch it on after you have read what it will send.

Guardrails

A rule asks an agent to remember. A guard does not need it to. The dangerous things belong in guards.

Block, ask, or allow

Claude Code runs small programs called hooks before and after every action an agent takes. A hook reads the action and answers one of three ways:

- **Block.** The action does not happen, and the agent is told why, so it changes its approach instead of retrying.
- **Ask.** Everything stops and the action is shown to you. Nothing happens until you approve it.
- **Allow.** Ordinary work, which is nearly all of it, goes straight through.

Block what is never right: a live key written into a file, a force push to the main branch, a recursive delete outside the project. Ask about what is sometimes right but cannot be undone: an email to a customer, a refund, a production deploy, a database statement that drops a table.

The ten we run

GUARD	ANSWER	WHAT IT STOPS
Words	Block	Phrases the business never writes
Secrets	Block	Live keys written into files
Schedules	Block	Two jobs on the same minute
Git	Block or ask	Force pushes, deleted main branches, skipped checks, discarded work
Deletes	Block	Recursive deletes outside the workspace
Sends	Ask	Anything emailed, texted or posted
Money	Ask	Charges, refunds, payouts, price changes
Deploys	Block or ask	Hand-pointed domains, production deploys from a laptop
Database	Ask	Drops, truncates, deletes and updates with no WHERE
Audit trail	Never blocks	Nothing; it records every action

A guard must never jam the work

A guard that blocks ordinary work gets switched off, and a switched-off guard protects nothing. So every guard is narrow, every guard is tested against ordinary commands it must allow as well as dangerous ones it must stop, and every guard allows when it hits an error of its own.

What never gets automated

- Marking a person as contacted.
- The first message to a new person.
- Anything that moves money.
- Anything that changes what a customer has already approved.

PAID FOR BY

A deploy from a laptop that overwrote a change another session had shipped an hour earlier, followed by a domain pointed by hand that took the site offline for an hour. Both are now guarded, and neither has happened since.

Shipping

"Shipped" is a claim about the live address, not about the change. If nobody has seen it live, the honest word is "merged".

Lanes

When several sessions work at once, each works in its own copy of the project on its own branch. Before touching anything, a session checks who else is working, and checks again before every commit and push. If someone else has changed a file it is about to change, it stops and tells you.

PAID FOR BY

Two sessions editing the same file on the same afternoon. The second push quietly erased the first one's work. Nothing conflicted and nothing warned; the loss was found the next day.

The preflight

In order, stopping at the first failure: fetch the latest version and rebase onto it, type check, lint, build, confirm no secrets are in the change, commit with a message that says what and why, push, open the pull request, and merge when the checks pass.

One way to production

Production ships by merging to the main branch, and the host builds it. A deploy typed from a laptop uploads whatever happens to be on that laptop and races every other change in flight.

Prove it is live

After the merge, fetch the live page and find something that exists only in the new version. Check that the commit the site is running matches yours. If the change is missing, find out why before blaming a cache.

Roll back first, debug second

When production is broken in a way customers can see, restore the last good version first. Then revert the bad change on main so the next build does not put it back, and fix it properly on a branch.

The incident note

After anything a customer saw: what they saw and for how long, what caused it in a paragraph you could read to a customer, how it was fixed, and what now makes it impossible. "Be more careful" is not an answer. A test, a check or a guard is.

Selling with a *crew*

The crew researches, drafts and follows up. You decide who hears from you and what they hear.

One person, one message

Every outreach message is written to one person about their business. If it could be sent to anyone else unchanged, it does not go. The message has four parts and stays under 120 words: one specific observation about them, one outcome in their terms, one line of proof, one small ask.

Only say what you checked

Every claim about a prospect's business comes from the live source, read today. Never tell someone their site lacks something unless the page was read and it was not there. Never print a guessed number about their revenue, their missed calls or their jobs. They know their real numbers, and a wrong guess ends the conversation.

Proposals

The crew reads every note and the prospect's own website, maps the work to one of your packages, and writes the proposal in their words: their situation, what you deliver as things they could point at, what is not included, dated milestones, the price stated once, and one next step. It arrives as a designed document, not a printed web page.

Follow-ups

Two at most, each adding something new. Any reply ends the sequence. Silence after a proposal is usually a busy week; a follow-up that brings a fresh observation respects that.

Contacted means a person

LAW

A lead is marked "contacted" only by a person. No automation, reminder, reply or self-booking sets it.

PAID FOR BY

An automation that set the flag after sending a reminder. The pipeline showed forty people as worked who had never spoken to anyone, and the follow-up list skipped every one of them.

Serving *customers*

Keep every customer, give them proof every month, and build things they own.

Onboarding in one pass

The day a customer says yes, the crew prepares the whole packet: the welcome email with the kickoff date and what you need by when, ten tailored intake questions at most, the access checklist with how to grant each login without sending a password, the scope confirmation word for word, and the dated milestones. The customer gets their own accounts in their own name.

The monthly review

On the first of every month the crew sweeps every live customer, read only: what shipped, what it changed in measured numbers, what broke and was fixed, and the one recommendation for next month. Each customer gets a one-page report and a short email. Every report waits for you. Only approved ones go.

Apologies

LAW

Customer email apologizes once at most, never in the subject line, and never explains our internal mistakes.

Say what is fixed and when. A paragraph explaining what went wrong inside your business tells the customer about a problem they had not noticed, and teaches them to look for the next one.

Adjustments are included

When a customer wants something adjusted on what you built, you do it. No price, no paperwork. Work that adds a deliverable you never agreed to build is a new package, offered as one.

Build things they own

The strongest retention is not dependency. It is a customer who could leave and does not want to. Every account is in their name, every key can be rotated, and every system comes with a one-page runbook. When a customer is ready to run it themselves, the handoff is a thirty-minute call where they do each step while you watch.

The idea *engine*

An owner who only reacts never gets ahead. Train the crew to bring you the next thing.

Three ideas every Monday

Every Monday the idea engine reads before it thinks: last week's customer emails and calls, your reviews and your competitors' reviews, your own parked notes, and what changed in your market. Then it brings three ideas, each with the idea in one sentence, the evidence quoted, who pays and roughly what it is worth to them, the smallest version you could ship in a week, and the strongest reason not to do it. It ranks them and recommends one.

The rule that makes it work: no idea without evidence. An idea engine that brings opinions is a newsletter.

Judging an idea

- Does the evidence come from customers, or from the agent's imagination?
- Could a smallest version ship in a week?
- Would a customer pay for that smallest version?
- Does it make the business more of what it is, or pull it sideways?

Kill or double down

Once a quarter, put every product, offer and channel through the same question: what did we expect, what happened in numbers, what does it cost in money and attention, the strongest case to stop and the strongest case to push, and the number that would change the decision by a date. Most small businesses carry something that should have stopped a year ago.

Build Week

The fastest way to learn whether an idea deserves more weeks is to give it exactly one. Monday: the brief, the acceptance test and the cut, approved by noon. Tuesday and

Wednesday: build in steps that each leave it working, with an attack pass at the end of each day. Thursday: every state, the finish pass, a real person tries it. Friday: the preflight, ship it, prove it is live, and put it in front of five customers.

The weekly *rhythm*

The whole company runs on a small number of habits, done on time.

WHEN	WHAT	WHO
Every morning	Read the briefing. Make the three decisions. Approve what is waiting.	You, fifteen minutes
Every morning	Overnight jobs, inbox triage, presence alerts, follow-ups due	The crew
Monday	Three ideas with evidence. Choose one or none.	Idea engine, then you
Wednesday	Read one week of front desk transcripts. Correct one thing.	You, fifteen minutes
Friday	Ship what is ready. Write the handoff notes. Clear the waiting list.	The crew, then you
Friday	The director's habit: one rule, one skill or one guard improved from this week's mistakes	You, fifteen minutes
First of the month	Monthly reviews for every customer, held for approval	The crew, then you
Weekly	The workspace doctor: rules, skills, hooks, memory, schedules	The crew
Quarterly	Kill or double down. What ten times the size looks like.	You and the crew

The director's habit

Every Friday, take the week's single worst moment (the email that had to be rewritten, the job that stalled, the question you answered twice) and make it impossible next week. Usually that is one memory note, one line in a skill, or one guard. Fifteen minutes a week of this is what makes a crew get better on its own instead of slowly drifting.

The *money*

Measure the crew the way you would measure a hire: what it costs, and what it replaced.

What a crew costs

Three lines, every month:

1. **The model subscription** the crew runs on.
2. **The tools** the crew uses: hosting, email sending, phone numbers, the database, the office your agents work in.
3. **Your time** directing it, which should settle near fifteen minutes a day plus a few hours a week of decisions and approvals.

Watch for metered charges. A job that calls a paid service in a loop can run up a bill overnight. Put a monthly ceiling on every metered service, and have the morning briefing report spend against it.

What it replaced

For each agent, write down what the job cost before: the hire you did not make, the contractor you stopped paying, the leads that used to go unanswered after hours, the evenings you used to spend on reports. Compare each month. An agent that does not beat what it replaced within sixty days gets a better brief or gets retired.

Where the money is

The biggest return is rarely the cost saved. It is the work that never happened before: every missed call answered, every customer reviewed monthly, every lead followed up twice, every idea tested in a week instead of discussed for a quarter. Count those too.

APPENDIX

The first *thirty* days

Tick each one as it is done. In order.

Week one: knowledge

- ☐ Rules file written: who you are, what you sell, how you write, pricing language, tools
- ☐ The twenty laws read; each kept, edited or deleted
- ☐ The ten guards installed and all tests passing
- ☐ Banned phrases set to match the rules file
- ☐ Five day-one memory notes written
- ☐ The brand-voice skill filled in

Week two: the first two agents

- ☐ Presence agent run once by hand; first score recorded
- ☐ Top three presence fixes made
- ☐ Front desk configured with your three qualifying questions
- ☐ Five test conversations run and every transcript read
- ☐ Front desk switched on
- ☐ Presence agent on a weekly schedule, on a minute nothing else uses

Week three: the rhythm

- ☐ Morning briefing running daily
- ☐ Heartbeats on every scheduled job
- ☐ First Wednesday transcript review done
- ☐ First Friday director's habit done
- ☐ Workspace doctor run once; every failure fixed or decided

Week four: the third agent and the first idea

- ☐ Third agent chosen, chartered and running
- ☐ First Monday idea engine report read
- ☐ One idea chosen for a Build Week, or none, with the reason written down
- ☐ Costs written down against what each agent replaced
- ☐ Thirty-day note written: what worked, what did not, what is next

AFTER THIRTY DAYS

You should be reading one briefing a day, making a handful of decisions, and approving what the crew drafted. If you are still doing crew work by hand, go back to the list from Chapter 1 and move one more job across.

LICENSE AND THANKS

Built to be *yours*.

This playbook is licensed to the Platinum or cohort seat holder for use in their own business. It may be shared inside that business. It may not be resold, republished or used to train others outside it.

The Studio Kit in your room holds the rules file, the twelve skills and the ten guards this book describes, ready to install. Questions go in your room during the run, and to sarah@modernmustardseed.com after it.

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